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Dinosaurs thrive at Charlotte's Jurassic Park

Raptor Center puts visitors eye to eye with today's feathered model

Special to the Observer

A dinosaur paid me a visit the other day. The walnut sized ball of hyperactive feathers had been casing my deck for several days and announcing his ownership of it to the immediate universe. So, when I left the door open for the dogs, he decided to check out the indoor facilities. They were not to his liking; he built his abode in a large azalea nearby.

Scientists' view of dinosaurs has changed a great deal since I was a girl. Then, my books described dinosaurs as large, lumbering lizards who might actually have died of stupidity. Years ago, no one would have suspected that my little Carolina wren is the first cousin, millions of times removed, of *Tyrannosaurus Rex*.

What do they have in com-



Mary Cunningham

mon, beyond a giant attitude? Lots, apparently. Many scientists now say that not only are birds the descendants of dinosaurs; they are dinosaurs.

Ostrich: T-rex with wings

The cap on all this was the 2003 finding of the massive leg bone of a tyrannosaur in the deep shale of Montana. Scientists found, to their amazement, that some soft tissue was preserved inside the leg. It was collagen, a protein, and close analysis found that it was nearly identical to the collagen of an ostrich. Give *Tyrannosaurus Rex* wings, and it would be a bird. Maybe it would taste just like chicken.

So Charlotte is fortunate to have its own Jurassic Park: the Carolina Raptor Center in Huntersville. There, you can visit creatures just as magnificent as

the creatures in the "Jurassic Park" movie – on a somewhat smaller scale, of course. Some, like kestrels and eastern screech owls, are almost as small as my little wren. Others are huge, as birds go: black vultures, ospreys and bald eagles.

Several of these birds have become well known citizens of our community. Who can forget the perils of Garibaldi, intrepid bald eagle and explorer? A severe storm in July 2005 caused the eagle aviary to collapse, and Garibaldi was flying free! The problem was, he couldn't fly well enough to hunt. Still, he was able to scavenge for food and elude would-be rescuers for seven months. After numerous "Garibaldi sightings," he was recaptured near Beverly Hills Elementary School in Concord, very thin, but otherwise healthy.

Then there are the dotting parents, Derek and Savannah, also bald eagles. Charlotte watched them hatch and raise Len and Lola, who were released a couple of years ago. You can still follow their daily travels at <http://gisserv.luncc.edu/website/eagles/viewer.htm>. This year, the center hopes for more progeny.

Don't try to raise raptors

I have my own favorites. The barred owl Omar is one. Omar was imprinted, and thinks he is a person. He especially likes to "hoot" at the ladies. Imprinting is a common form of injury in the birds at the center. Someone will find a cute, fuzzy little owlet and try to raise it as a pet, visions of Hogwarts dancing in her head. But when an adult owl lands on her head, the dream will be a nightmare, for the human and the owl alike. Those talons are sharp. Trust me; I know whereof I speak.

You can't release such an owl, or an imprinted hawk; it does not now know how to find its own food. And as a side note, keeping these birds is illegal; you can get a big ticket for it. So if you find a nest of barn owl eggs or an orphan baby kestrel, contact the center immediately. The experts there will foster it (some of the birds at the center make excel-



FILE PHOTO

Marge Sowden, a volunteer at the Carolina Raptor Center, releases a red tail hawk in 2006.

lent foster parents) and will make sure it is taught how to catch its own food. It will have to get past Mouse School to graduate to a tree near you.

Another of my favorites is Bob O, a barred owl who suffered the most common injury to raptors: a collision with a car. Bob O is

blind. Seventy-five percent of an owl's head is made up of its eyes; if your own eyes were as big as an owl's, proportionately, they would be the size of grapefruits. Any head injury will likely affect an owl's eyes. Car injuries are common because we humans so often throw food out of our cars. The food attracts the mice and rats that are a raptor's favorite dinner items. Not even these tough, smart, feathered dinosaurs have any defense against two-ton metal objects moving at 80 mph.

So, come on down to Jurassic Park South! Volunteer (especially if you don't mind cutting up rats). Donate. Adopt, either one of the residents, or an orphan scheduled for release. Or just commune with some of the most beautiful creatures on the planet.

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